Elena Smirnova, MSc

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Citizenship: Austria

PROFILE

I am a project manager and researcher with more than 15 years of experience in designing, managing and evaluating international programmes in development cooperation, humanitarian assistance, and research and consulting projects.
My work focuses on peace policy, gender equality, democratic resilience and decolonial perspectives on societal transformation. Geographically, my work concentrates on Eastern Europe, the Western Balkans, the South Caucasus and Central Asia.
I have extensive experience managing publicly funded projects (EU institutions and agencies, Austrian Development Agency, ministries), developing and coordinating international consortia, and assuming full budgetary and contractual responsibility. My work combines strategic project management with in-depth political and governance analysis, particularly in fragile and authoritarian contexts.
In addition, I bring academic expertise in International Development, with a focus on feminist and decolonial peace research, as well as experience in university teaching and academic publishing.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Strategic Project and Programme Management
- Management of complex national and international projects
- Full responsibility across the entire project cycle
- Budget planning, financial controlling and contract management
- Risk management in fragile and politically sensitive environments
- Leadership and coordination of interdisciplinary teams

Fundraising and Consortium Development
- Development and submission of national, EU and international funding proposals
- Establishment and coordination of international partnerships and consortia

Thematic Expertise
- Peace and conflict research
- Gender studies, gender equality and institutional equality policies
- Democratic resilience and authoritarian contexts
- Participatory peace processes
- Civil society in authoritarian environments
- Decolonial perspectives on governance and development
- Regional transformation and cohesion processes

Media and Public Engagement
- Editorial conception, moderation and production of political radio and podcast formats
- Bilingual public communication (German/Russian)
- Feminist perspectives and transnational dialogue formats

LANGUAGES

Russian:	Native
German:	Fluent (written and spoken)
English:	Fluent (written and spoken)
Ukrainian:	Basic knowledge

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Visiting Lecturer
Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt, Austria
Summer Semester 2026
Course: 560.102 (26S) – „"Peace from Below. Feminist Visions and Practices Against the War in Ukraine and Russia"

- Independent design and teaching of the course
- Supervision and mentoring of student research projects

Project Manager & Gender Equality Officer
The Vienna Institute for International Economic Studies (wiiw), Vienna, Austria
October 2024 – March 2026

Project Management

- Acquisition and development of national and international research and cooperation projects in economic and social development in Eastern and South-Eastern Europe
- Full project cycle management (conceptualisation, proposal writing, consortium coordination, implementation, evaluation)
- Cooperation with EU institutions, ministries and international partners
- Coordination of interdisciplinary research teams
- Preparation of funding applications, budgets and reports

Gender Equality

- Co-responsibility for implementation and further development of the institutional Gender Equality Plan (GEP)
- Monitoring of gender-related indicators and institutional measures
- Advisory role on gender equality within projects and organisational development
- Contribution to mainstreaming gender aspects in research and institutional strategy

Regional Manager
Hilfswerk International, Vienna, Austria
September 2019 – August 2024

- Overall responsibility for development cooperation and humanitarian programmes in Eastern Europe, the Western Balkans and the South Caucasus
- Management of publicly funded projects (EU, ADA, foundations), including contract management, budgeting, financial controlling and reporting
- Leadership and technical support of local teams and partner organisations
- Development and submission of project proposals within international consortia
- Establishment of strategic partnerships with donors and civil society actors
- Political context and risk analysis in sensitive environments

Assistant Regional Managers
Hilfswerk International, Vienna, Austria
March 2019 – August 2019

- Operational support in project monitoring, financial controlling and reporting

Project Coordinator
PKF Tourismexperts, Vienna, Austria
June 2018 – February 2019

- Market development and project acquisition in tourism and regional development
- Stakeholder management in Eastern Europe, the South Caucasus and Central Asia

Teaching Assistant
Institute of Geography and Regional Research, Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt
October 2015 – February 2016 / October 2016 – February 2017

- Tutorials in physical geography, cartography, geoinformation and remote sensing
- Development of teaching materials and student support

Project Associate
Kohl & Partner GmbH, Villach, Austria
April 2009 – February 2017

- Participation in international tourism and regional development consulting projects
- Market analysis and project development

Environmental Consultant
Energoconsulting, Moscow, Russia
June 2008 – September 2008

- Consulting in quality and environmental management

Consultant and Auditor for Management Systems
Ural Interregional Certification Centre, Ekaterinburg, Russia
September 2006 – May 2008

- Consulting in quality and environmental management
- Implementation of ISO 14001 and OHSAS 18001 systems
- Internal and external environmental audits

EDUCATION

Doctoral Programme in Social Sciences: Development Studies (PhD)
University of Vienna, Austria
Since October 2025

Working title of dissertation: "Antimilitarism and Decolonisation: Civil Society Actors in Russia and Ukraine between War and Peace"
Research focus:
- Feminist peace and conflict research
- Decolonial theory
- Civil society resistance in the context of the Russia–Ukraine war
- Critical discourse analysis and qualitative research methods

MSc in Geography and Regional Research (Geographical Systems Sciences)
Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt, Austria
Graduated 2018 (with distinction)

Diploma Engineer in Environmental Protection and Sustainable Use of Natural Resources
Ural State Technical University, Yekaterinburg, Russia
Graduated 2006

FURTHER EDUCATION AND PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Advanced Programme in Transdisciplinary Peace Studies
Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt / University of Vienna
Completed 2025

Advanced Programme in Gender Studies
Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt / University of Vienna
Completed 2024

Crisis and Disaster Management
Austrian School of Applied Studies
Completed 2023

Certificate in Sustainable Development
Faculty for Interdisciplinary Research and Continuing Education,
Alpen-Adria University Klagenfurt
Completed 2015

PUBLICATIONS

Smirnova, Elena (2025). Buchrezension: „Krieg und Friedensbewegung: Feministische Perspektiven“. *Wissenschaft & Frieden*, 4/2025: Autoritäre Wende: Repression – Militarisierung – Faschisierung, pp. 63–64. [Book review: “War and the Peace Movement: Feminist Perspectives”]

Preiml, Stefanie; **Smirnova, Elena**; Weisbach, Eva; Zeil, Moremi; & Egner, Heike (2018). Schutz vor wem, für wen? Zur Frage der Tragfähigkeit des Naturschutzes im Anthropozän. In Heike Egner & Horst Peter Groß (eds.), *Die Reihe „Klagenfurter Interdisziplinäres Kolleg“*. [Protection from whom, for whom? On the sustainability of nature conservation in the Anthropocene.]

Smirnova, Elena; von Elverfeldt, Kirsten; & Egner, Heike (2018). Wie kommt der Klimawandel in unsere Gesellschaft? Von wissenschaftlicher Erkenntnis zur gesellschaftspolitischen Agenda. In Kirsten von Elverfeldt & Heike Egner (eds.), *Systemtheoretische Geographie* (= *Klagenfurter Geographische Schriften* 30). Klagenfurt: Institut für Geographie und Regionalforschung, pp. 10–17. ISSN 2308-9849. [How does climate change enter society? From scientific knowledge to a socio-political agenda.]

CONFERENCES

Working Group for Peace and Conflict Research (AFK) – Colloquium 2026
“Ideas and Interfaces in Peace and Conflict Research: The Importance of Inter- and Transdisciplinary Research” Leipzig, Germany.
Presentation: “Beyond Security: Feminist and Decolonial Visions of Peace in the Context of the Russia–Ukraine War.”

MEDIA AND PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

Freelance Journalist & Radio Producer
Radio Agora 105.5, Radio Orange 94.0
2015 – 2025

- Conceptualisation, production and moderation of the bilingual programme „Russische Stunde – Русский час“
- Production of the feminist radio programme “Subject Woman – Women’s Perspectives from Around the World”
- Member of the editorial team “Global Dialogues – Woman on Air”

Focus areas: feminism, authoritarianism, transnational dialogue and diaspora debates.

CIVIL SOCIETY ENGAGEMENT

Active involvement in civil society networks addressing peace policy, gender equality and democratic resilience, with a focus on Eastern Europe and EU contexts.

Strategic networking across academia, civil society and policy communities, and participation in public discourse spaces addressing militarisation, authoritarianism and societal transformation.

Regular lectures, panel contributions and moderation on democratic resilience, gender equality, antimilitarism and transformation processes in Europe.

PROJECT PORTFOLIO (SELECTED)

I. EU & Policy Research Projects (wiiw)

Production and Analysis of Cedefop's New European Skills Forecast

Duration: 09/2024 – 08/2028
Client/Funding Institution: CEDEFOP
Role: Project Manager

Framework contract for producing and further developing EU Skills Forecasts across Member States, including coordination of project activities, methodological development and policy-oriented reporting.

Production and Analysis of Cedefop's New European Skills Forecast – Specific Contract No. 1

Duration: 10/2024 – 10/2025
Client/Funding Institution: CEDEFOP
Role: Project Manager

Update of the European Skills Forecast, including refinement of modelling assumptions, validation of projections and preparation of analytical outputs.

Production and Analysis of Cedefop's New European Skills Forecast – Specific Contract No. 2

Duration: 05/2025 – 04/2026
Client/Funding Institution: CEDEFOP
Role: Project Manager

Continuation of forecast production activities under the framework contract, including methodological adjustments and analytical reporting at EU and Member State level.

Production and Analysis of Cedefop's New European Skills Forecast – Specific Contract No. 3

Duration: 11/2025 – 03/2026
Client/Funding Institution: CEDEFOP
Role: Project Manager

Targeted update of projections and preparation of deliverables for EU policy stakeholders.

Production and Analysis of Cedefop's New European Skills Forecast – Specific Contract No. 4

Duration: 11/2025 – 12/2025
Client/Funding Institution: CEDEFOP
Role: Project Manager

Further update and analytical enhancement within the established forecasting framework.

Revision and Update of the Study "Danube Region Monitor – People and Skills" (including Online Database)

Duration: 03/2025 – 11/2028
Client/Funding Institution: Federal Ministry of Labour and Economy (Austria) & Austrian Agency for Education and Internationalisation (OeAD)
Role: Project Manager

Update of the Danube Region Monitor covering 14 countries within the EU Strategy for the Danube Region (EUSDR), including data harmonisation, thematic analysis and development of the online dashboard.

Distributional Income and Employment Effects of Fiscal Policy: Micro-level Evidence for Austria (DIEFISCAL)

Duration: 07/2025 – 06/2027
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Academy of Sciences (ÖAW)
Role: Project Manager

Research project analysing the income and employment effects of tax and transfer reforms in Austria using narrative fiscal shock data combined with administrative microdata.

Couples' Transition to Parenthood and Labour Market Outcomes in Austria (CoPLAN)

Duration: 07/2025 – 06/2027
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Academy of Sciences (ÖAW)
Role: Project Manager

Register-based analysis of gender inequalities in labour market outcomes during the transition to parenthood.

DAWIT – Evidence-Based Approaches to Public Service Provision and Regional Economic Development

Duration: 11/2025 – 11/2026
Client/Funding Institution: Federal Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry, Climate and Environmental Protection, Regions and Water Management (Austria)
Role: Project Manager

Policy-oriented project developing quantitative and qualitative tools to support evidence-based regional transformation and public service provision.

Economic Impact and Potential of Formal and Informal Roma Employment in Eastern Europe

Duration: 03/2025 – 11/2026
Client/Funding Institution: Roma Foundation for Europe
Role: Project Manager

Socioeconomic and labour market analysis assessing the economic contribution and inclusion potential of Roma communities in Central and Eastern Europe and the Western Balkans.

Tax and Contribution Burdens in Firms with Different Value Creation Structures

Duration: 12/2024 – 06/2025
Client/Funding Institution: Chamber of Labour Lower Austria
Role: Project Manager

Analysis of structural differences in tax and social contribution burdens across Austrian firms based on microdata.

Towards a New EU Anti-Poverty Strategy

Duration: 03/2025 – 06/2025
Client/Funding Institution: European Committee of the Regions
Role: Project Manager

Analysis of poverty and social exclusion trends in the EU and development of evidence-based policy recommendations.

Analysing Subnational Reform Needs and Investment Priorities in Germany

Duration: 06/2025 – 12/2025
Client/Funding Institution: European Commission, DG Regional and Urban Policy (DG REGIO)
Role: Project Manager

Territorial analysis of structural reform needs within the European Semester framework.

Advice on Intra-EU Mobility and Social Security Coordination (Lot 2)

Duration: 12/2021 – 11/2025
Client/Funding Institution: European Commission, DG Employment, Social Affairs and Inclusion (DG EMPL)
Role: Project Contributor / Research Coordination

Provision of independent expertise on free movement of workers and social security coordination within an international consortium.

Web Intelligence Hub (Framework Contract)

Duration: 01/2025 – ongoing
Client/Funding Institution: EUROSTAT
Role: Project Coordination

Coordination of project contributions within an EU-wide data and monitoring framework contract.

II. Humanitarian Assistance & Emergency Response (Hilfswerk International)

Restoration of Critical Infrastructure in Ukraine

Duration: 11/2022 – 08/2023
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Development Agency (ADA), Nachbar in Not
Role: Project Manager

Rehabilitation of electricity, heating and water supply systems in war-affected regions.

Holistic Humanitarian Assistance for Conflict-Affected IDPs in Ukraine

Duration: 08/2022 – 02/2024
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Development Agency (ADA), Nachbar in Not
Role: Project Manager

Integrated humanitarian support for internally displaced persons and vulnerable populations.

Emergency Relief and Protection for IDPs in Ukraine and Refugees in Moldova

Duration: 04/2022 – 10/2023
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Development Agency (ADA), Nachbar in Not
Role: Project Manager

Coordination of cross-border emergency response and protection measures.

III. Development Cooperation & Governance

Sustainable Strengthening of Local Health Systems in the Western Balkans

Duration: 07/2021 – 01/2023
Client/Funding Institution: Federal Ministry of Social Affairs, Health, Care and Consumer Protection (Austria)
Role: Project Manager

Health system strengthening and knowledge transfer in mobile care services.

Empower Youth for Active Citizenship in Moldova

Duration: 08/2018 – 11/2021
Client/Funding Institution: Austrian Development Agency (ADA), IFA
Role: Project Manager

Programme promoting youth civic engagement and democratic participation.

Step by Step Towards a Better Future (Phase II) – Rehabilitation and Reintegration in Georgia

Duration: 02/2017 – 07/2020
Client/Funding Institution: European Union, Austrian Development Agency (ADA)
Role: Project Manager

Vocational training, mentoring and reintegration support for prisoners and former inmates.

IV. International Consulting & Regional Development (Tourism)

Tourist Master Plan – City of Cheboksary, Russia

Duration: 01/2015 – 09/2015
Client/Funding Institution: Tvorchesky Gorod
Role: Project Consultant

Tourist Master Plan – Republic of Tatarstan, Russia

Duration: 11/2012 – 12/2013
Client/Funding Institution: Tourism Development Center, Kazan
Role: Project Consultant

Tourist Development Action Plan – South Kazakhstan Province

Duration: 06/2013 – 08/2013
Client/Funding Institution: Ministry for Sport and Tourism
Role: Project Consultant

Market and Potential Analysis – Krasnoyarsk Krai, Russia

Duration: 04/2011 – 09/2011
Client/Funding Institution: Foundation Center for Strategic Research "North-West"
Role: Project Consultant

Tourism Audit – Yamalo-Nenets Autonomous Region, Russia

Duration: 01/2010 – 02/2010
Client/Funding Institution: Yamaltour
Role: Project Consultant

Tourism Audit – City of Berdsk, Russia

Duration: 10/2009 – 11/2009
Client/Funding Institution: City Administration of Berdsk
Role: Project Consultant

V. Environmental & Management Systems

Development and Implementation of Integrated Management Systems (ISO 9001, ISO 14001 & OHSAS 18001)

Duration: 02/2007 – 05/2008
Client/Funding Institution: AK Korvet, Kurgan, Russia
Role: Consultant and Auditor

Implementation of integrated environmental and occupational health and safety management systems, including internal and external audits.